SED functionary Günter Schabowski remembered the shop sold everything from Colgate toothpaste, Milkana cheese, and designer suits to Western Hi-Fi and video equipment. ‘We granted ourselves what we could not give to the common man,’ he revealed with merciless candour.5 In the nursery alone – dotted with large greenhouses – up to thirty people worked to cultivate fresh herbs, fruit, vegetables and flowers.

In the beginning, there were communal evenings and Ulbricht occasionally arranged dinners and film screenings, but that ‘soon petered out’, Honecker was to recall. As Erich’s bodyguard Lothar Herzog attested, his boss was ‘quite sociable’ in the early sixties and ‘would come with some of his colleagues to the clubhouse’ – the male-dominated Wandlitz ‘F-Club’ – and play skat and ‘have a brandy or a beer every now and then’. Herzog, a captain in the Ministry of State Security, was responsible for Honecker’s personal protection and his physical well-being. Many waiters at Wandlitz remembered the table manners of the well-lubricated Politburo were ‘in need of improvement’ – people told dirty jokes, slurped, farted, burped and spoke with full mouths. Honecker continued to hurriedly shovel food with a fork, like in his youth. ‘He was definitely not a connoisseur,’ Herzog admitted. Pyotr Abrasimov, the Soviet Ambassador, occasionally dropped in and struck up a friendship with Honecker. Unlike his predecessor, Abrasimov took a high-profile approach to his duties, visiting factories, exhibitions and appearing on television as well as fully enjoying the privileges of a Politburo member. Although, Honecker showed him respect, given Abrasimov had fought against the fascist Okku-Panten as an officer with the Belorussian partisans, their relationship would soon falter. In private, Honecker’s security detail accused Abrasimov of being so vain that he used to dye his mane of silver hair, which, after rinsing, transmitted a blueish tint.6

As will be seen, with the collapse of the GDR thirty years later, Wandlitz cast a cloud over Honecker’s reputation. ‘Whenever that place is mentioned, I still feel a mixture of shame, anger and resignation,’ Schabowski confessed. ‘Did we, I wonder, have to further morally compromise our cause and ourselves?’7 Honecker, though, lashed out at allegations of living a charmed existence. Put on the defensive, his former valet (another bizarre contradiction) embellished tales of his sedentary